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IARCO – YANGON CYBER GUARDIAN (YCG) PROJECT

Full Legal Name: Zyne Latt Oo

Institution: IIP International School

Category: Junior

Class/Grade/Year: O Level

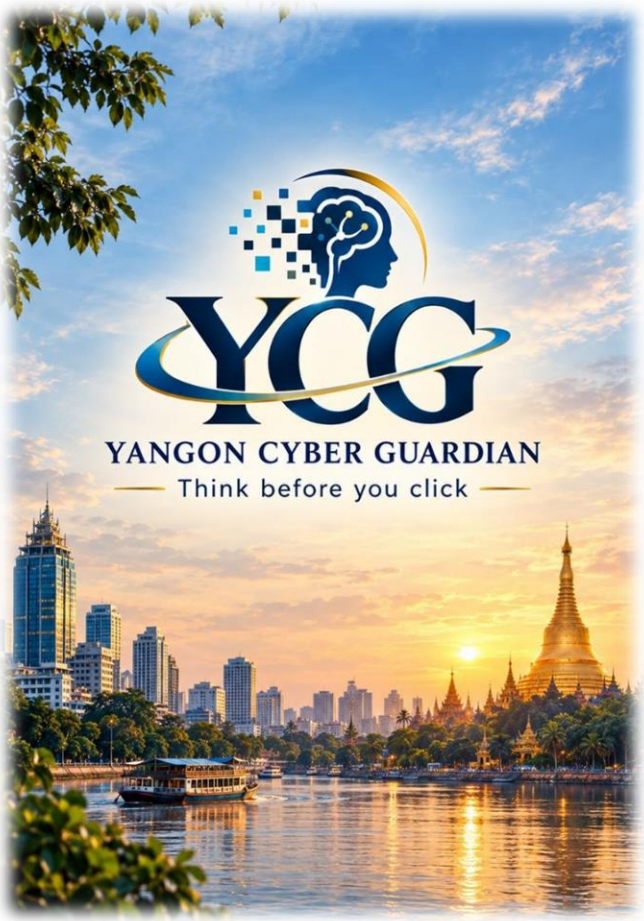
Country: Myanmar

Submission Date: September 30, 2025

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Research Topic: Improving Cybersecurity Awareness and Scam Prevention Among Teenagers in Yangon

YANGON CYBER GUARDIAN



This picture is fully AI-generated content for temporary use as the YCG logo.

Background

A proper understanding of cybersecurity is necessary to achieve a secure, safe, and free internet. According to Tim Berners-Lee, the inventor of the World Wide Web, privacy, information, and the rights of people should be protected due to an increased reliance of the whole world on the Internet. He also expresses concerns about personal data use and the need for users, companies, and technology developers to collaborate in creating a secure and trusted cyberspace [1].

Internet freedom has been threatened in Myanmar because of regulations imposed on the Internet and an increase in Internet prices that hinder communication and information exchanges and social media use. Political instability has greatly affected the country's cybersecurity situation [2].

The lack of information and digital literacy may expose Myanmar to online scams. Fraudulent practices may involve impersonating legitimate sources, fundraising through fabricated accounts, investment fraud, advance-fee deception, and phishing. Limited ability to identify trustworthy and dishonest information may lead to monetary loss or personal information theft [2], [3]. Therefore, cybersecurity awareness and scam prevention are crucial research areas in Myanmar.

Research Questions

YANGON CYBER GUARDIAN (YCG) is a proposed community-based project in Yangon that aims to promote safer and more informed use of digital technology. This study is intended to answer the following questions:

1. To what extent are teenagers within the selected study population aware of cybersecurity risks and threats associated with their use of social media?
2. What are the common cybersecurity problems faced by teenagers, such as online scams, cyberbullying, online violence, hacking, phishing, and pharming?
3. To what extent can cybersecurity education enhance teenagers' awareness and ability to protect their personal information through digital-literacy initiatives, school-based education, and public awareness programs?
4. How can reported scam activities be carefully evaluated to identify recurring patterns, emerging trends, and potential warning indicators of online fraud?

Literature Review

How Does China Raise Cybersecurity Awareness?

China uses a series of strategies that involve public awareness campaigns, education programs, and laws to ensure the promotion of cybersecurity awareness. Every year, National Cybersecurity Week holds activities that involve government agencies, schools, businesses, communities, and the public. [4].

China has also introduced measures to strengthen online safety for minors [5]. Moreover, educational institutions also help in raising cybersecurity awareness among students through various campus activities, advertising, contests, and education regarding fraud, personal information security, and internet safety [6]. China's Personal Information Protection Law also strengthens awareness by protecting personal information, including children's data, automated decision-making, and cross-border data transmission [7], [8]. These efforts combine education and legal protection to improve cybersecurity awareness.

How Does Thailand Raise Cybersecurity Awareness?

Thailand utilizes digital-literacy education and community-based programs to improve cybersecurity awareness. One such initiative is the ETDA Digital Citizen program of the Electronic Transactions Development Agency, which involves lectures, online programs, videos, and face-to-face activities to raise awareness of cybersecurity, online safety, digital security, identity protection, and responsible technology use [9], [10].

Another noteworthy program is the EDC Trainer, which trains selected individuals to promote digital safety within their communities, and ThaiCERT offers e-learning and MOOCs to support cybersecurity education for the public, government, and businesses [11], [12]. These examples demonstrate Thailand's commitment to community-based cybersecurity education.

Cybersecurity Education in Myanmar

Several initiatives in Myanmar are dedicated to cybersecurity education. For example, mmCERT offers awareness-raising activities and organizes the Myanmar Cyber Security Challenge, with 2026 activities focused on developing cybersecurity human resources, raising awareness among young people, and enhancing technical expertise. It also organized a Cyber Security Awareness Video Competition at the university level [13].

Another initiative is DigiSec Lab, which provides free online digital-security courses, including safe Internet use, account security, device security, and secure communication [14]. Moreover, there is Stop Online Harm, which offers digital safety resources in Myanmar and explains how one can report online harassment through its Digital Safety Kit [15].

Research on online scams in Myanmar reveals that factors such as low digital literacy, financial constraints, and limited consumer protection contribute to the prevalence of scams. Common fraud methods include fake banking information, investment fraud, impersonation, and phishing [3]. These issues highlight the need for cybersecurity education and awareness in Myanmar. In this regard, cybersecurity education in Myanmar is crucial. However, the current initiatives are not enough.

Methodology

1. Research Design: For this study, an experimental, quantitative research design approach will be adopted involving a one-group pretest-posttest design approach. This means that, for this particular study design, the participants' level of awareness of the issue of cybersecurity will be assessed using a pretest; thereafter, the participants will undergo the cybersecurity awareness program, after which a posttest will be conducted, and the results will be compared to establish whether there has been any change in the level of awareness among the participants.

2. Study Population and Participant Selection: The target population will include teenagers within a defined age range, currently studying in selected Yangon schools, who are regular Internet/social-media users. Purposive sampling will be used to select schools and students who meet the study criteria and are relevant to the research objectives. The research team will first obtain permission from the relevant school authorities. Eligible students will then be invited to participate. Participation will be voluntary, and no unnecessary personal information will be collected.

3. Research Variables

Independent variable: The cybersecurity awareness program, which will include presentations, posters, discussions, demonstrations, and digital-literacy lessons about scams, cyberbullying, phishing, hacking, pharming, fake accounts, suspicious links, and how to protect personal information.
Dependent variable: The level of cybersecurity awareness among teenagers, measured by questionnaires completed before and after the cybersecurity awareness program. These include:

- Ability to identify suspicious messages, accounts, websites, and links
- Knowledge of personal information protection
- Knowledge of safe password and account practices
- Awareness of online scams, cyber threats, and online violence
- Understanding of appropriate responses to suspicious online activities

Since the study is based on one group measured before and after the intervention, the change in the dependent variable will be investigated by contrasting pretest and posttest scores.

4. Pretest and Posttest: The questionnaire will be given as a pretest before conducting the cybersecurity awareness program and the posttest at the end of the program. The pretest will measure the baseline knowledge about cybersecurity awareness among the participants. The cybersecurity awareness program will be carried out, and a posttest will be conducted. The gap between the pretest and posttest will be assessed.

5. Cybersecurity Awareness Program: The intervention shall comprise education programs meant to improve the participants' awareness and digital literacy.
These include:

- Threats in cybersecurity presentations
- Posters and visual aids for learning
- Anonymized real-world case studies
- Suspicious messages and links identification
- Protecting your personal information
- Safe use of social media sites
- The concepts of phishing, pharming, and online frauds
- Actions to be taken if you encounter any suspicious online activity

The content will be designed according to the weaknesses identified through the pretest.

6. Collection and Analysis of Scam Reports: Appropriate publicly accessible scam reports will be collected from using a website. The reports will be categorized using a content-analysis framework.

The researchers will use descriptive analysis to identify recurring patterns and warning signs. The findings will be used to supplement the questionnaire data and address the research question concerning prevalent cybersecurity issues.



7. **Evaluation and Recommendations:** The success of the cybersecurity awareness campaign can be measured through the evaluation of the test scores before and after the participants have been educated. The areas that score poorly on the test will be determined and can

become the focus of further education. Analysis of the scam reports will help to determine the methods, patterns, and signs of the scams. Based on this analysis, recommendations for further action can be made.

The findings can also be used to make recommendations for future YCG cybersecurity awareness campaigns.

Expected Results

- Determine the level of cybersecurity awareness among the selected group of teenagers.
- Identify the gaps in impersonation, fake accounts, and unsafe information requests.
- Evaluate the changes in levels of cybersecurity awareness after the program.
- Detect common characteristics and warning signs in online scam reports.
- Recommend practical approaches to raising cybersecurity awareness in schools and communities.

Ethical Considerations

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- Participation in the study will be voluntary, and the objective of the research will be explained to the participants.
- For participants below 18 years, permission from the school, parent/legal guardian, and the participant will be sought.
- Only essential personal information will be collected and kept confidential.
- Passwords, financial information, and private account details will not be collected.
- The study will not publicly identify or accuse individuals of being scammers.
- The collected information will be used for research and reporting purposes only.

Limitations

- The study population in Yangon may not be entirely representative of all teenagers in Myanmar.
- The number of participants may be limited by availability in the selected communities.
- The results of the questionnaires may reflect self-reported levels of knowledge rather than actual practices in online interactions.
- The study analyzes short-term changes and may not indicate long-term behavioral changes.

Conclusion

Cybersecurity awareness plays a crucial role in protecting individuals from online scams, cyberbullying, phishing, impersonation, and other digital threats. The YCG project will focus on teenagers in Yangon to raise cybersecurity awareness, detect common scams, and provide them with essential education to stay safe online. By running awareness programs, establishing reporting platforms, and collaborating with communities and relevant organizations, the project will contribute to empowering individuals to safeguard their personal and financial information and promote a secure cyberspace in Myanmar.

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